

VIENTIANE LAOS

Laap in Leisurely Laos

Often dubbed the most laid-back nation in Asia, Laos is a country where people live by a very natural rhythm. Vientiane may be its capital city, but it remains as much a series of villages as a true metropolis. Lao cuisine shares much with that of Isan across the Mekong in northeastern Thailand, with a sharp and tangy palette of flavors typified by the dish known as *laap*.



While other Southeast Asian capitals have surged into the 21st century with swift economic development, mushrooming skyscrapers, jammed traffic, cluttered highways, and ever-spreading urban sprawl, Vientiane has set itself on a far more sedate path. Its leisurely spread along the northern shores of the Mekong River is still one mostly characterized by sparsely trafficked boulevards and quiet alleys.

The real name for the city is Wieng Chan – “City of Sandalwood.” It has endured a torrid history over the last two centuries, being overrun by both Burmese and Chinese marauders. In 1828 it was comprehensively sacked by the Thais, leaving temples smashed and broken, streets empty, and Lao nationhood in tatters. The country rose again as a French protectorate toward the end of the 19th century, and it is their colonial-style buildings, together with magnificent Buddhist stupas and pagodas, that give the city its character, along with the slumberous movement of the mighty Mekong River that runs through it. The streets in the Chanthabuli district in the center of the city stretch back from the

Mekong, intersected by the main boulevards of Samsenthai Road and Sethathirath Road. This is the heart of the city and the place to wander, linger, and eat.

Lao cuisine, like that of neighboring Isan in Thailand – whose inhabitants are ethnically the same people – is defined by fragrant fresh herbs, citrus, and pungent fish sauce, and *laap*, the flagship Laotian salad, has them all in spades. It is most often made using beef, chicken, pork, or sometimes fish, thinly sliced, chopped, or minced, with flavorings that vary from region to region and, indeed, chef to chef.

Typically, the meat or fish is stir-fried quickly over high heat with chili peppers, lemongrass, and garlic, then mint, lime juice, lime rind, pepper sauce, peanuts, onion, and cilantro are stirred in. The whole mixture is then spooned onto lettuce leaves. Roughly ground, toasted rice (*khao khua*), vital to the character of the dish, is added as a topping, garnished with mint leaves or heady Thai basil. Even when served with the meat still warm, and with the ubiquitous basket of sticky Lao rice on the side, the result is so delightfully refreshing that you’ll soon be ready to stroll the streets once more.

What Else to Eat

Lao cuisine is derived using ingredients mainly from the wild or from the rice field. **Kop yat sai**, or stuffed frog, is something of a delicacy.

Naem khao (rice-and-sausage ball) is a salad made with deep-fried rice balls, grated coconut, chopped peanuts, Lao fermented pork sausage, sliced shallots, mint, cilantro, lemon juice, and fish sauce. **Foe** (rice noodle soup) is very similar to Vietnamese *pho* (see pp238–9), and is the ubiquitous breakfast dish in Laos. **Tam mak hoong** (green papaya salad), literally meaning “pounded papaya,” is a sharp and spicy salad made from unripened papaya. Barbecued chicken, or **ping kai**, is a favorite in every street market in Laos. It is marinated in a delicious mixture of fish sauce, garlic, turmeric, coriander, and white pepper, then slowly grilled over low heat on a charcoal burner.



Above *Laap* combines all the sharp and tangy tastes so characteristic of the region



The Best Places to Eat Laap

Nang Khambang inexpensive

For a no-nonsense taste of *laap* at its finest in genuinely authentic, everyday Lao surroundings, Nang Khambang is the place. The name means “Mrs. Khambang,” and it’s a family-run eatery that has been in the same location for three generations. Everything here is of the highest quality, and the *laap* is no exception. The restaurant offers air-conditioned and non-air-conditioned seating and, in a country where service can be slow, the staff are very attentive and efficient. In addition to the *laap*, Nang Khambang offers excellent *paa neua on*, a kind of lightly grilled and seasoned freshwater fish. Also on the menu are Mekong River fish and a sour fish soup, not unlike Thai *tom yam*, called *kaeng som paa*. Their *tam mak hoong* (green papaya salad) is also excellent; here it comes with tiny freshwater shrimp and baby tomatoes. Although Nang Khambang is now well publicized among travelers and tourists, it is still also heavily patronized by a Lao clientele – always a sure sign of quality. Nor have the prices been raised beyond the reach of local people.

Khum Bulom, Vientiane; open noon–9 PM daily; +856 21 217 198

Also in Vientiane

Amphone (+856 21 212 489; expensive) is a gourmet affair where Lao cuisine is given an international “makeover.” It is set in beautiful surroundings and the ambience is one defined by chic furnishings, subdued jazz, and a fine wine list. The *laap* here is one of many excellent renditions of Lao culinary standards, as is the steamed fish citronella in banana leaves.

Also in Laos

Luang Prabang is the ancient capital of Laos and is an exquisite little town in the mountains now protected as a UNESCO World Heritage site. In addition to the plethora of ancient temples and the beauty of the French-era colonnaded streets, it is home to some very fine restaurants. **Tamnak Lao (www.tamnaklao.net; expensive)**, housed in an old French colonial villa, offers an extensive menu of artfully prepared Lao dishes including *laap* with pork, chicken, or fish.

Around the World

Given the colonial history of Laos, it is no surprise that the best purely Lao restaurants outside the country itself are found in Paris (although Isan Thai restaurants are found all over the globe and the food is hugely similar).

Lao Lane Xang (+66 1 45 85 19 23; moderate) is to be found in Paris’s bustling Chinatown district. It is hugely popular for both lunch and dinner thanks to its low prices, excellent service, and the authenticity of the Lao fare served. It is a good idea to make a reservation.